

FDE FIELD NOTES · ISSUE 01 OF 10

# Start from the workflow, not the model.

Shadow the 7am queue before you open a notebook.

01

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**Akhilesh Ranjan Singh**

Senior DevSecOps Engineer · [github.com/iarsingh](https://github.com/iarsingh)

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# Four questions I ask on day one

## 01 Who does this today?

A name and a role, not a department.

## 02 What starts it?

The trigger: an email, a queue, a shift change.

## 03 What does done look like?

The output someone else depends on.

## 04 What happens when it is wrong?

Who notices, how fast, and what it costs.

# Map the workflow first

1 Trigger

2 Intake

3 Decision

4 Handoff

5 Record

Mark the one step where a person spends judgment. That is the only candidate for automation — everything else is plumbing.

# Two ways to start

## MODEL-FIRST

- Pick a model, find a use
- Demo on clean sample data
- Success = accuracy number
- Operator meets it at launch

## WORKFLOW-FIRST

- Shadow the operator
- Replay last month's real items
- Success = queue time, errors
- Operator shapes the rules

## SCENARIO: NIGHT SHIFT

**“I need to explain it at 2am.”**

One sentence from a night lead removed a ranked-search design and replaced it with a written priority order the next shift can recompute.



# Before any build

- ☒ Shadowed the real operator
- ☒ Workflow drawn on one page
- ☒ Judgment step identified
- ☒ Baseline time and error rate
- ☒ Owner who can say no
- ☒ Old path stays available

## KEY TAKEAWAY

# The workflow is the spec. The model is an implementation detail.

- Shadow before you design
- Automate one judgment step, not the whole job
- Keep the old path running

## YOUR TURN

**What is the first question you ask a customer before proposing any AI?**

FOLLOW AKHILESH RANJAN SINGH

**Next in the series: #02 A constraint should delete a design**

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